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Skin in the Game: On AI and Accountability in Scientific Work

by Jana Möller-Herm

A few months ago, researchers developed an artificial intelligence (AI) system called the “AI Scientist”. They submitted three fully machine-generated manuscripts to a workshop of a top-tier machine learning conference and one of them passed the first round of peer review. The AI system had autonomously generated the idea, searched the literature, planned and run the experiment, analyzed the results, drafted the manuscripts, and even simulated peer review, end to end, with no human involvement at any decision point¹. As a researcher who has spent her career making such decisions, one at a time, I find this moment unsettling. It may be a foretaste of AI aiding scientific discovery, but it deserves more than the cautious optimism with which it has often been greeted².

My concern is not that AI will write our papers for us. AI already does, in pieces, and much of that assistance is genuinely useful. My concern is that the very idea of a paper as a chain of accountable acts by someone who chose this question, this method, this interpretation, and who stakes their name on each of them is quietly being hollowed out. The growing literature on AI slop in academic publishing describes this from the symptom side: machine-generated text polluting journals, references that do not exist, reviews written by the same models that wrote the manuscripts under review³. I want to describe it from the cause side: what disappears when no one is left to make the small, accountable choices that constitute scholarly craft.

The argument is simple: science needs skin in the game. By that I mean researchers who carry the cost of their own choices, who can be wrong, who can be criticized, who can defend a theoretical commitment because it is theirs. A research project, whether a survey study, a qualitative interview series, or a theoretical paper, is the product of countless choices made at every scale: which phenomenon is worth investigating, which theoretical lens to adopt, how to phrase an item in a questionnaire,

which control variable to include, how to frame a finding in the discussion, which sentence to open the abstract with. Each one is small. Together they are the work.

Ted Chiang, an American science fiction writer, has made a related point about art: what looks like creative output is in fact the cumulative weight of countless small decisions, and a prompt of a hundred words cannot stand in for the ten thousand decisions a short story requires⁴. He emphasizes that the “small-scale choices made during implementation” matter as much as the “large-scale choices made during conception”, and that the interrelationship between the two “is where artistry actually lies”. The same logic, I want to argue, applies to scientific work. Choices are epistemic and ethical. They are the place where a scholar commits.

Where the choices go

AI is no longer a hypothetical tool at the margins of academic work. I write from social science where AI can already assist at every stage of the workflow. At the ideation stage, researchers prompt large language models to brainstorm research questions, identify under-explored angles, or stress-test the novelty of a planned contribution. During the literature review, tools such as Elicit, Consensus, and Research Rabbit retrieve and synthesize prior work, while general-purpose models summarize papers, extract key findings, and draft related-work sections. Theory building, long considered the most distinctly human part of the craft, is increasingly supported by AI as well: models articulate mechanisms, generate hypotheses, formalize conceptual relationships, and surface analogies from adjacent literatures. At the data collection stage, AI drafts and refines survey items, generates interview questions, and even substitutes for human participants using synthetic respondents, also called “AI personas”⁵. Downstream, models write and debug analysis code, assist in qualitative coding, identify themes in interview transcripts, and produce initial interpretations of statistical output. During writing, they draft abstracts, restructure arguments, polish wording, and tailor manuscripts to the conventions of specific journals. Finally, AI has entered peer review from both sides: authors use it to anticipate reviewer concerns, while reviewers use it to summarize manuscripts and draft critiques.

Each of these uses, taken alone, is defensible. Taken together, they describe a quiet migration. The small-scale choices that constitute scholarly craft are moving, one by one, out of the researcher's hands and into a system whose outputs look like ours but originate elsewhere. With The AI Scientist, that migration reaches its endpoint: a pipeline that closes the loop entirely, with no human decision-maker left inside.

The author who isn't there

It is tempting to describe such a system as an autonomous researcher. It is not. As computer scientist Jaron Lanier has argued, “there is no A.I.” in the strong sense. What we call AI is better understood as a form of “social collaboration” with the millions of humans whose texts, data, and judgments were absorbed into the training set, a collaboration the interface is designed to obscure⁶. The AI Scientist is not a new kind of scholar; it is a compressed, anonymized aggregate of human scholars, with their names stripped off and their accountability dissolved.

Bender et al. sharpen this point from the linguistic side: the fluency we attribute to AI is itself an illusion of authorship⁷. Large language models, they argue, are “stochastic parrots”: systems that stitch together linguistic forms according to probability distributions in their training data without any real-world understanding of what they generate. Like a parrot that mimics human speech. The fluency and coherence of AI output invite readers to project understanding where there is none. In a research context, this matters. A paper is a claim that someone is making. When a paper is produced without an underlying claimant, the genre is preserved, but its function is hollowed out.

Science slop and the dead-science horizon

What this hollowing looks like in practice already has a name: “AI slop”. Low-effort, machine-generated content that imitates the surface of a genre without contributing to it has begun to appear in academic publishing under the label “science slop”. Recent reporting documents a wave of AI-generated manuscripts with flawed or fabricated citations entering the literature, particularly in fields with high publication

pressure⁸. The harm is not only quantitative: AI slop pollutes the infrastructures researchers depend on⁹. Specifically, the massive increase in AI-generated research content overwhelms the peer-review process. Today, reviewing such submissions is more work than creating them. As a result, journals and their pool of reviewers increasingly lack the resources to separate quality research from AI-generated science slop.

One way to see where this trajectory leads is to borrow a phrase from internet culture. The “dead internet” thesis holds that an increasing share of online activity is machine-generated content interacting with machine-generated content, with human participation reduced to ornament¹⁰. A “dead science” version of the same dynamic is not difficult to imagine: AI-assisted authors submitting AI-generated papers to AI-screened journals reviewed by AI-summarized reports. Each step is locally rational. The aggregate is a literature in which nobody is, in any meaningful sense, saying anything to anybody.

Already in October 2025, researchers from Stanford University held the first Agents4Science conference, in which all of the papers were produced and reviewed by machines. In December 2025, a separate group launched a preprint repository, known as aiXiv2, that uses AI to review submissions and actively encourages machine-generated papers¹¹.

Skin in the game

So what is the alternative to a literature without authors? It is not a refusal of AI. Used well, these tools genuinely extend what a researcher can do, and pretending otherwise would be dishonest. The alternative is to insist on what AI cannot supply: someone who has chosen, and who can be held to that choice.

Science, on this view, is not primarily a corpus of findings. It is a chain of accountable acts. Researchers select a question because they believe it matters, design a study because they believe it will speak to that question, interpret a result because they have lived with the data long enough to know what it can and cannot bear, and sign their name because they are willing to be wrong in public. Each of these is an act in

which something is at stake for the person performing it, what Nassim Taleb has called “skin in the game”¹². AI systems, however capable, have no skin in any game. They face no personal consequences, they cannot be held accountable, they cannot be wrong in the way a scientist needs to be able to be wrong. This is not a deficit to be engineered away. Yet, these are the things responsibility is made of.

This has a practical implication for scientists. The test is not whether AI was involved in producing a paper – it almost always will be – but whether a human author can, in good faith, stand behind every substantive choice the paper embodies. The question to ask of any AI-assisted step is: “Can I still defend this if pressed?” Where the answer is yes, the tool has served the craft. Where the answer is no, something has been outsourced that should not have been.

I am writing this article because I think the choice between a living and a hollowed-out science is still ours. It will be made, or unmade, in the small choices each of us takes: which sentence to write ourselves, which result to interpret on our own, which review to draft without delegation. The signature on the paper is still ours to give. Whether we keep giving it, whether we mean it, is up to us.

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